



“Deepening liquidity, expanding product ecosystem, strengthening ease of doing business and building a talent ecosystem will go a long way in making GIFT more attractive”

VIJAY KRISHNAMURTHY

MD & CEO, INDIA INX
(SUBSIDIARY OF BSE)

42 |



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ASHOK GAUTAM

MD & CEO, INDIA INTERNATIONAL
BULLION EXCHANGE

test-protocol it and I think launch in six months. That will be unassisted, that is, I will be able to look into my mobile phone and create an account. At present, you can do an assisted video customer identification process, where you need to launch a video call with a fund manager here,” says Rajaraman.

Separately, the IFSCA has authorised CDSL Ventures, a subsidiary of Central Depository Services India Ltd, as a KYC registration agency. Once it's operational, investors won't have to do multiple KYCs, he says. Rajaraman points at plans to onboard more payment service providers to open access to more jurisdictions.

Unexpected changes in rules in India are another concern. A classic case is what happened in bullion trading last financial year. In March 2025, volume of gold traded on IIBX in GIFT IFSC crossed 100 tonnes. That was significant, as in FY24, volumes were just around eight tonnes. However, volumes plunged in 2025-26, even as gold prices were surging. This was due to a tussle over allocation of import quotas (tariff rate quotas under the India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership).

“We were confident of doing around 130 tonnes in FY26. However, unexpected policy changes and then affected parties going to court hurt bullion trading last year,” Ashok Gautam, the MD and CEO of IIBX, tells *BT*. He explains that the DGFT gave only provisional quota initially and put in a clause that anyone with a turnover below ₹25 crore would not be considered. The matter went to court, and by the time the order came, it was September, he says. The DGFT,

to widen the participation, cancelled the quota and decided to go for competitive auctions. That has been challenged in the Rajasthan High Court.

GIFT IFSC can take advantage of the US-Israel war on Iran, which has raised question marks over Dubai's reputation as an island of peace and stability, say experts. “Global capital gravitates towards stability rather than volatility, and India's strategic autonomy, macroeconomic resilience, and democratic institutions position it as safe haven,” says Krishnamurthy. He adds deepening market liquidity, expanding product ecosystem, strengthening ease of doing business and building a global talent will go a long way in making GIFT City attractive.

One issue is lack of social infrastructure and lifestyle facilities. But things are changing, say consultants. A new hotel is coming up, there is metro rail connectivity to Ahmedabad, there is a school, and the Lilavati Hospital is setting up a super speciality facility. Also, several foreign universities like Deakin of Australia and Queens University of Belfast have set up campuses there. A riverfront is also being developed, says Runit Parikh, senior director and retail branch head (Ahmedabad) at Knight Frank. “We are seeing a huge pickup in real estate, particularly residential, in areas in and around GIFT City,” he adds. IFSCA Chairperson Rajaraman says India has the execution capability to develop a greenfield IFSC. The vision is now to make GIFT IFSC a dominant gateway for capital flows into India and leverage India's talent advantage to become a strong exporter of international financial services. **BT**

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